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# Oral Exams for a Generative AI World: Managing Concerns and Logistics for Undergraduate Humanities Instruction

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**ABSTRACT**
The emergence of generative artificial intelligence has forced humanities educators to reconsider traditional assessment methods, particularly take-home writing assignments vulnerable to content produced by generative artificial intelligence. This paper examines the implementation of oral exams in an upper-level humanities course as a response to generative AI. Using backward design principles, the author redesigned the entire course structure to support oral assessment, implementing technology-free classrooms, social annotation platforms, and systematic "cold calling" to prepare students for final oral examinations. The paper addresses common concerns about oral exams, including student anxiety, fairness, and instructor time management, through evidence-based strategies and careful implementation. The author found that oral exams not only effectively addressed AI-related academic integrity issues but also helped students develop critical communication skills. Students reported positive experiences and improved understanding of course material, while instructor time investment proved comparable to traditional paper grading. This research contributes to pedagogical literature by providing practical guidance for implementing oral exams in humanities courses, demonstrating their effectiveness as both an AI-resistant assessment method and a valuable tool for developing essential academic and professional skills. While acknowledging limitations, the study offers a viable alternative for upper-level humanities instruction in an increasingly AI-integrated educational landscape.

**KEYWORDS**
Academic integrity; assessment methods; generative artificial intelligence; humanities pedagogy; oral examinations

The rise of generative artificial intelligence[1] has forced us humanities educators to fundamentally reassess our standard assessment methods. Like many professors, I used to build my courses around traditional written assignments–weekly reading responses and research papers–because that was how I had been taught and how I believed students developed critical thinking skills. Yet the emergence of AI that can generate passable reading responses and essays has raised serious academic integrity concerns while challenging the effectiveness of these time-tested methods.

Faculty already struggle with heavy teaching loads, post-Covid teaching challenges, contingent employment, and declining public support for the humanities. Generative AI adds another layer of complexity. We can ignore it, embrace it, or adopt temporary workarounds to outsmart an AI that will only get better with time. This essay describes what happened when I chose a fourth option: a complete overhaul of my assessment methods.

I present my experiences redesigning an upper-level history course on Tibetan Buddhism where I implemented oral exams, a method that is rarely used in contemporary humanities classrooms. What began as a practical response to academic integrity issues evolved into a complete reimagining of how we can assess and develop advanced humanities skills. Through careful implementation of oral exams, supported by research-based preparation methods and anxiety management strategies, this approach not only addresses academic integrity concerns but enhances the development of critical thinking and communication skills that lie at the heart of humanities education.

Relatively little has been published on the use of oral exams in humanities courses, particularly as a response to Generative AI. Existing literature focuses primarily on STEM fields, likely because quantitative assessments offer clearer metrics for measuring learning outcomes. This article contributes to the pedagogy

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literature by demonstrating that oral exams provide an effective assessment method for upper-level humanities courses in the AI era. While this method will not work for all courses, and has disadvantages, it offers a valuable and practical option for instructors seeking alternatives to take-home writing assignments.

## The problem of assessment in an age of AI

When ChatGPT publicly launched in late November 2022, I was fortunate to be heading into a sabbatical that spring. I experimented with the technology myself and watched colleagues struggle with academic dishonesty without much support or guidance from our institution. In Summer 2023, I had my online students sign honor pledges and made clear AI policies, but academic dishonesty still occurred. Even after moving to in-person blue book exams that fall, I discovered AI-generated content in what seemed like the most personal, low-stakes assignment: weekly mindfulness journal entries in my History of Meditation course. In a way, I understood where the students were coming from–they are juggling many responsibilities and may wonder about the practical benefits of humanities courses. Still, I felt disappointed, and wondered if I had not done enough.

This problem extends beyond my classroom. Generative AI threatens to render traditional take-home writing assignments obsolete while turning instructors into plagiarism detectives. While instructors might hope they can inspire students to do their own work the difficult way, this strikes me as unrealistic. Students face increasing pressures, and if they are staring down a late-night deadline, it is reasonable that they would want to use a tool that could provide some help. Meanwhile, faculty manage larger courses with less job security (Jones 2023), and AI detection software is unreliable, biased against ESL learners, and easily circumvented. Any technological workarounds will become obsolete as AI improves.

Some might ask: why does generative AI pose a problem for educators? Perhaps we should be teaching students how to use AI since employers will increasingly demand such skills. This raises a fundamental question: what is the goal of a college education? Is it for job training or education of the whole person? Both are clearly important, but my heart lies with the latter. I believe the deeper purpose of liberal arts education is transformation—helping students think critically, read analytically, and engage thoughtfully with unfamiliar ideas. Students may forget the facts from my Buddhism courses, but I hope they retain skills for lifelong learning and critical thinking. It matters to me that students learn to do the hard work of reading, generating ideas, organizing their thoughts, finding evidence, considering their audience, and communicating clearly–even when all of that could be done passably by AI.

Consider two ways of lifting weights: manually or with a forklift. Each has their own place. When a worker needs to move a lot of weight quickly, they use a forklift. But when that same person wants to build muscle, they head to the gym and lift weights themselves. The goal determines the tool. In liberal arts education, the primary objective isn't simply to produce polished essays (we have plenty), but to build intellectual muscle—the fundamental reshaping of how students think, question, and understand the world. This transformation happens only through the intellectual struggle of wrestling with complex ideas, forming arguments, confronting contradictions, and revising understanding. When students consistently outsource this cognitive work to AI, they're essentially using a forklift when they should be in the gym. They may accomplish the immediate task more efficiently, but they miss the deeper purpose of education: to become someone capable of holding complex ideas from multiple perspectives.

Given all of this, I decided I would have to change my assessment methods entirely. I wanted something that would be impossible to fake with AI, something that was practically achievable given my schedule, and something that could give students an opportunity to work on needed skills. I decided to use oral exams.

## Why oral exams?

Oral examinations have a long history. From Socratic dialogue to medieval European universities' *viva voce* examinations to (in my own field) Tibetan monastic debates for advanced geshe degrees, oral assessment was once the norm (Stray 2001, Dobson 2018, Dreyfus 2003). The shift to written exams in the late 19th and early 20th centuries reflected practical concerns. Rising enrollments and a desire for greater standardization and grading efficiency rendered oral examination logistically challenging (Stray 2001, Dobson 2018, Spolsky 1990). Colleges implemented written exams that could be taken by many students simultaneously (Dobson 2018), and many instructors also adopted the "term paper" or "research paper" (Moulton and Holmes 2023).

While oral exams are less common now, they are still alive. Oral exams are common in various international settings, including Germany (Kehm 2001), Denmark (Isager 2024), and the British medical

system (Roberts et al. 2000). In the US, they live on in the form of thesis and dissertation defenses. While they are less common as a form of assessment for individual courses, some instructors have described their recent experiences using final oral exams in their courses including in courses in STEM (Akkaraju 2023, Gardner and Giordano 2023, Hazen and Hamann 2020, Huxham, Campbell, and Westwood 2012, Roecker 2007, Theobold 2021), business (Akimov and Malin 2020, Bayley, Maclean, and Weidner 2024), and the social sciences (Buehler and Schneider 2009, Hazen 2020), or have identified important dimensions of oral exams for instructors to consider (Joughin 1998). Many of these papers report instructors' experiences with oral exams, describe how to administer them, and offer advice to faculty considering their use. Most of these are case studies rather than attempts to quantify the impact of oral exams, but the authors are generally positive about their experiences. Authors commonly praise oral exams' interactive nature as allowing for assessment of deeper understanding and for tailoring the exam to the student, while also acknowledging that these exams are novel and often anxiety-provoking for students.

When deciding to implement oral exams, I adopted some practices described in these papers. When drawing from the existing literature, I found Buehler and Schneider 2009 to be the most useful when designing my oral exams, especially their emphasis on working backwards from student learning objectives and specific implementation strategies such as allowing students to record the oral exam. I also followed Hazen 2020's advice to give students a list of possible exam questions ahead of time, and Theobold 2021's guidance about how to create an online sign-up sheet to schedule exams. However, this paper also differs from existing literature on oral exams in that it introduces implementation strategies not discussed in any of the papers cited above. Specifically, none of the above papers describe using cold calls or social annotation platforms—which I will describe below—as ways to prepare students for oral exams.

## Implementation strategy

After reviewing this history and research, I decided to implement oral exams in my own course. This then required redesigning the classroom experience using backward design principles. That is, because students would be asked in the oral exams to respond to complex questions, think on their feet, and synthesize readings, I structured the classroom experience to provide low-stakes opportunities to practice those skills.

First, however, it is worth describing the course and student population in more detail. This course took place at a medium-sized (10,000 students) public R1 university with a 95+% acceptance rate. Tibetan Buddhism is a 300-level course cross-listed in history and religious studies. In the Fall 2024 semester, there were twenty-five students. There are no pre-requisites, but most students were junior or senior history or religious studies majors. Almost all were native English speakers and full-time, traditional-age students. The course met twice a week for an hour and fifteen minutes each session, and the format was lecture-based with plenty of interactive questions and answers.

My first change I made was to ban laptops and phones from the classroom. Students had to bring in paper copies of readings and notes, unless the student had an official accommodation. I made this easy on students by providing a full PDF file of all the semester's readings in one document and providing instructions about how to print it half-size and double-sided at the library, where the full semester's readings could be printed for about ten dollars. Students were initially skeptical, but ample evidence shows that phones and laptop use in class reduces learning for the user and other students (May and Elder 2018, Ravizza et al. 2017, Sana, Weston, and Cepeda 2013), that handwritten notes improve memory (Mueller and Oppenheimer 2014), as does using physical copies of readings (Singer and Alexander 2017, Clinton 2019).

I uploaded PDF files of the readings to the free group annotation platform Perusall, along with reading prompts that highlighted key themes in the text. Perusall is a fairly new platform, but studies suggest that it may support motivation, course community, and higher grades (Clinton-Lissell 2023, Cui and Wang 2024, Shaker, Brignell, and Pugh 2025). Students completed the assignment by making five annotations per week on the course readings, which I graded on completion rather than quality to minimize time spent grading. This platform enabled peer interaction and helped me gauge students' interests and struggles as I prepared for class. I also highlighted exemplary annotations in class to model good practices.

To prepare students for the final oral exam, I implemented random calling (what I called "the hot seat," also known as cold calling) rather than relying on volunteers. In the past, I found relying on volunteers typically leads to a pattern where some students participate and others opt out entirely. Many instructors shy away from random calling, as they may not want to put students on the spot. However, pedagogy research consistently suggests that active learning improves educational outcomes (Kozanitis and

Nenciovici 2023, Deslauriers et al. 2019), and cold calling enhances active participation. Other pedagogical research suggests that cold calling increases student preparation (Levy and Bookin 2014), that it increases both overall *and voluntary* student participation (Dallimore, Hertenstein, and Platt 2013), that it does not meaningfully increase student discomfort in class (Dallimore, Hertenstein, and Platt 2013). There are also several case studies that give advice for effectively implementing cold calls (Waugh and Andrews 2020, Dallimore, Hertenstein, and Platt 2013).

To manage the logistics of the hot seat, I kept a stack of notecards with each student's name written on it and randomly pulled cards to select respondents. At least five students were called in each class, with normal voluntary question and answer from students interspersed throughout. Following backward design principles, the questions asked mirrored those I planned for the oral exam, and matched the reading prompts from Perusall, making the cold calls somewhat predictable and incentivizing preparation. For grading, I used the back of each notecard to track performance with a simple system: a check in the top third indicated a strong response, the middle third showed adequate performance, and the bottom third marked absences or students who chose to "pass." At mid-semester, I sent students individual "check-in" emails about hot seat and Perusall performance, offering praise and constructive feedback. At the end of the semester, I dropped the lowest third of cold calls before assigning grades– a system that allowed quick, efficient assessment while encouraging consistent participation.

To prepare the oral exam, I used my course learning goals as a basis. I wanted students to understand important events in Tibetan history, to analyze primary and secondary texts, and to communicate complex ideas clearly. I created twelve synthesis questions that were open-ended enough to allow for multiple correct answers but required students to synthesize multiple readings and provide specific examples to illustrate their points. As examples, here are two questions from the oral exam:

> Throughout *Eat the Buddha*, we have seen multiple people face death, whether that be their own death or a loved one's death. Describe at least two different people's deaths (they should be importantly different). How does the person die, and how do they or their loved ones deal with this death? How does this death illustrate or complicate general Tibetan Buddhist approaches towards death?

> Let's imagine that you are a historian advising the U.S. Congress on what its Tibet Policy should be. What is Tibet, and why are people fighting over it? Has Tibet ever been independent? What policy towards Tibet should the US pursue? How involved should the US get? (Make sure to keep it simple, because you are talking to politicians)

I gave the students the questions two weeks before the final exam, allowing them time to prepare. They were also allowed to bring a page of handwritten notes to the final oral exam as an aid. I also provided students with a rubric (included as an appendix A) to let them know how they would be assessed. To give students some choice, I allowed them to "veto" one question they did not want to answer, and to pick a question that they wanted to start with. Then, I used a random number generator to select three more questions for them to answer in the twenty-five-minute exam period.

Logistics were manageable: I scheduled thirty-minute slots using Google Calendar signup, accommodating twenty-five students in twelve and a half hours over one week. The exams themselves took twenty-five minutes, allowing me five minutes to grade each exam immediately using the rubric. During the exam, I gave students a copy of the questions to look at and read the questions to them. I took notes on a sheet of paper and filled out the rubric in the few minutes between exams. Students were allowed to record the oral exam using the voice memo app on their phones if they wanted to listen back. After the exam, students were asked to turn in a two-page reflection evaluating their performance and preparation. This aimed at fulfilling the learning goal of critical self-reflection.

## Addressing concerns

### *student anxiety*

One major concern about oral exams is about student anxiety. While it is true that students are experiencing increased anxiety (Ahmed et al. 2023, Sheldon et al. 2021), I do not think that this is a reason to abandon oral exams. Many people fear public speaking or oral exams, but avoidance tends to intensify rather than relieve anxiety (Piccirillo, Dryman, and Heimberg 2016, Helbig-Lang and Petermann 2010, Arnaudova et al. 2017). Students will have to do anxiety-provoking activities in their professional and communal lives, and I believe it is better to help them practice in a supportive classroom environment than avoid oral exams out of a misplaced desire to reduce student distress.

Instead of avoiding the anxiety-provoking dimension of oral exams, I chose to acknowledge to students

that oral exams and cold calling will be stressful, but that this stress could be productively managed. This allowed me to empathize with students and build buy-in. I proactively discussed anxiety research with students, demonstrating that I had thoughtfully considered their concerns. I showed how repeated exposure reduces anxiety over time (Kaplan and Tolin 2011, Abramowitz, Deacon, and Whiteside 2019) and that a bit of discomfort ("desirable difficulty") enhances learning (Bjork and Bjork 2020, Ringeisen et al. 2019). More importantly, I shared practical and evidence-based anxiety-management strategies, including cognitive reframing (Ringeisen et al. 2019, Stocker and Gallagher 2019), preparation (Levy and Bookin 2014, Hsu and Goldsmith 2021), and deep breathing (Peper et al. 2022), among other techniques. I also created supportive structures: consistent cold-calling routines to build predictability (Dallimore et al. 2013), a classroom culture where mistakes are seen as learning opportunities (Cooper, Downing, and Brownell 2018), and clear expectations to reduce uncertainty (Nash, Crimmins, and Oprescu 2016, Hsu and Goldsmith 2021).

### *Fairness and standardization*

Another potential concern is unfairness. In the past, oral exams were often conducted by multiple examiners (Dobson 2018, Stray 2001), which reduced potential for bias. This was not possible in my case, so I implemented several safeguards to ensure fairness. I provided questions and a rubric ahead of time, allowed students to record their exams on the voice memo app for potential appeals, and maintained consistent grading and examination methods across students. If a student wanted to request that another faculty member be present during the exam, I would allow that. These measures particularly support students who might face additional challenges—first-generation students, ESL learners, or those with disabilities—by providing preparation time, transparency, and a method for appeals. While complete objectivity is impossible in humanities assessment (just as with grading papers), clear expectations and consistent procedures minimize potential for unfairness.

### *Instructor time management*

The most frequent concern raised by fellow instructors is that oral exams would take too much time to administer and grade. I designed the course so that it could be taught in the ten hours a week allotted per course in my job description. I tracked my hours using the free time management tool Toggl Track (track.toggl.com) and found that the total time spent administering and grading oral exams for the Tibetan Buddhism Fall 2024 course was less (thirteen hours) than the total time spent grading twenty-five midterm papers and twenty-five final papers for my Tibetan Buddhism Fall 2021 course (fifteen hours, plus procrastination time). Since cold calls occur during class, they require no additional grading time outside of brief notecard tracking. While oral exams require intensive time during exam week, they eliminate the prolonged grading periods that written assignments demand. However, I encourage instructors to track their actual time investment to make informed comparisons.

## Results and discussion

My experiences with this course structure were very positive, and so I have shifted to make this my standard assessment format for upper-level courses. I continue to tinker with the specifics but have largely retained the format described here.

The oral exams offered various unexpected benefits. I could tailor questions to individual students by giving gentle prompts to students who seemed a bit lost and pushing advanced students even further in their analysis. The assessment process felt transparent: it was clear to both the student and to me how the exam had gone. In their post-exam self-evaluations, students gave themselves largely accurate grades, and no one has contested a grade to date.

Beyond addressing AI concerns, oral exams develop skills employers consistently report as lacking in recent graduates: verbal communication and professional behavior (Moore and Morton 2017, Bauer-Wolf, 2018, Coffelt and Smith 2020, NACE 2025, Clokie and Fourie 2016, Intelligent 2025). Faculty often complain that, after Covid-19, students seem to struggle with anxiety and professionalism. Oral exams address these concerns head-on by offering students ways to practice speaking skills and learning to think on their feet in a supportive environment (Kleckner and Butz 2021). Traditional methods of exams or papers, by contrast, do not develop these skills. While I resist reducing education to job training, these practical benefits help secure student and administrative buy-in for what is fundamentally valuable pedagogy.

Students also reported positive experiences in their course evaluations (anonymously collected by the registrar) and final reflections (turned in as part of the course). For the hot seat, students wrote, "I liked the hot seat, it made me actually do the readings for class

and comprehend what they said," "I think the hot-seat system was a great addition to class that both encouraged students to do the readings but allowed them to not be penalized for having a bad day," and "I also enjoyed the hot seat and also focusing on critical skills outside of just a classroom-context like public speaking and interviewing skills." While I would have preferred that students do the readings because of intrinsic interest in the subject, it appears that the hot seat provided enough extrinsic motivation to incentivize them to keep up with the readings.

For the oral exam, students often reported that it was less scary than initially feared. One wrote, "Altogether, I felt like the oral exam went very well. The preparation was much more stressful than the actual test, and it was a great break from the endless paper-writing for other history and religion classes I have taken. During the oral exam, my stress melted away when I started just talking about what I learned over the course of the semester. It was great to have another human engaging with what I was saying and asking questions as I answered to see what I learned. This was my favorite part of the oral exam and I hope to be able to take more tests like this." Multiple students also described the experience of preparing for the oral exam as helping them understand the material better. For example, "I didn't struggle in the exam itself too much, but with the notes and the preparation I struggled a lot. Having to hunt down the correct answers in the course materials, both the readings and the powerpoints [sic], was a struggle and a half. This definitely led to me knowing the answers more and being more confident in my notes though." Some reported the experience of listening back to the oral exam, and described what they would do in future interviews or similar situations. For example, "Upon listening to the recording, I was initially struck by the way I spoke. I have a tendency to mumble or slur my words, speak quickly, and interrupt or correct myself mid-sentence. That can be confusing as a listener….In the future, I'd like to slow down a bit and take a moment to think about what I'd like to say and how to say it." While such data from course evaluations and student self-reflections is anecdotal rather than systematic, overall, I felt that these responses indicated that the exam format was successful in helping students understand the material and develop skills in oral communication.

While I have spent this article arguing for the use of oral exams, I know that this is not a universal solution. Oral exams are time-prohibitive at class sizes above twenty-five students, meaning that it is not a solution for large introductory courses. Some have suggested that large courses can still use oral exams if they use video software to record the exams (Bayley, Maclean, and Weidner 2024), but this approach does not allow for back-and-forth. Oral exams can also introduce bias based on communication style or cultural background (Roberts et al. 2000), and some students may try to please the instructor rather than master the material (Isager 2024). Significantly, oral exams also do not develop writing skills, which remain crucial. Generative AI has complicated how humanities instructors teach writing, but this is still an important skill students should develop. Ideally, oral exams should complement, not replace, writing instruction as part of a broad education.

Another limitation is student resistance to some of these new methods. This was especially the case for cold calling, which is understandable, as no one likes to be put on the spot. Studies also show that while active learning methods increase student understanding, students often prefer to listen to straight lectures and will even (erroneously) report learning more in that format (Deslauriers et al. 2019). Students would sometimes groan aloud when called or joke about how they hoped they would not be called. As someone who wants students to like me, I sometimes felt tempted to abandon the cold calls in favor of allowing student choice in participation. However, I do feel that the cold calls helped incentivize preparation and improved participation in the oral exams, and decided it was worth being the "bad guy" if I believed in the method. This approach was supported by the course evaluations, where students did report that they disliked the hot seat. Often, however, they would qualify this dislike, as in these examples from course evaluations: "Though I'm not a big fan of the 'hot seat' it is an effective way to ensure that I actually complete the class material and notes" or "I was not a fan of the hot seat but I understand the reasoning." Ultimately, to return to the gym versus forklift analogy, if I want students to treat the classroom like a gym, I should be willing to be the personal trainer who pushes them even when they do not want to be pushed.

Ultimately, success in this method depends on building student trust and buy-in. Students will embrace unfamiliar assessment methods if they understand why the instructor is adopting the method, see that they have thoughtfully addressed potential problems, and genuinely believe in the approach's value. Sticking with the methods we instructors have used for years and that students understand is in many ways the path of least resistance. But Generative AI use is only going to grow, and the challenges it poses for college instruction will only become more

substantial. Hopefully the research and logistical advice provided above helps instructors better understand oral exams as a viable option and present it to students, colleagues, and administrators.

## Note

1 Many have raised the question of whether AI is in fact intelligent enough to merit the name and have preferred to refer to these systems as Large Language Models (LLMs). I sidestep the question of whether AI is intelligent and use it as a convenient designator for systems like ChatGPT, Google Gemini, Claude, or other similar tools.

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## Statement on research participants

This study was deemed to not need Institutional Review Board Approval by the University of Wyoming IRB. Anonymity of students is maintained throughout the paper.

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## Appendix A. Rubric for Final Oral Exam

**Table A1.** Oral exam rubric: Tibetan Buddhism.

| | Exemplary | Proficient | Developing | Below Standards |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Overall Understanding 20** | Shows a deep/robust understanding of the topic with a fully developed responses to questions.<br>Understands and illustrates key methodological approaches and concepts, makes original and insightful points. | Shows a sufficient understanding of the topic, makes good points, but some uneven understanding or inaccuracies.<br>Explanations of concepts and approaches are mostly complete, and no significant errors made, can repeat ideas discussed in class but may not be able to move beyond | Shows a superficial understanding of the topic. Explanations of concepts and approaches are inaccurate or incomplete, but some information is accurate. | Shows insufficient to no understanding of the topic. Little references made to overall concepts, approaches.<br>Student can parrot some things said in class but does not understand them. Major issues with inaccuracies. |
| **Argument 20** | Clearly articulates a position or argument when asked.<br>Anticipates and responds to counter-arguments well | Articulates a position or argument that is incomplete or limited in scope<br>Responds to some counterarguments | Articulates a position or argument that is unfocused or ambiguous<br>Responds to some counterarguments, but unfocused | Does not have a position or argument<br>Cannot respond to counterarguments |
| **Evidence 20** | Presents evidence that is *relevant and accurate* that supports argument | Presents evidence that is *mostly relevant and/or mostly accurate* the supports argument | Presents evidence that is *somewhat inaccurate and/or irrelevant* to argument, but corrects when prompted | Presents *a lot of inaccurate and/or irrelevant* evidence and so does not support argument, even when prompted repeatedly |
| **Structure, Coherence, Organization 20** | Thesis is clearly stated and developed in a way that is accessible to listeners, there is logic in the progression of ideas | Most information presented in logical sequence; generally organized but better transitions from idea to idea needed | Ideas are somewhat disjointed and/or do not always flow logically, making it a bit difficult to follow, concepts loosely connected | Ideas are disjointed and/or do not flow logically, hence argument is very difficult to follow |
| **Speaking and Presentation Skills 20** | Poised, clear articulation; proper volume; steady rate; good posture and eye contact; enthusiasm; confidence; rich and varied vocabulary and grammar, minimal verbal clutter | Clear articulation but not as polished, uses appropriate vocabulary and grammar, keeps verbal clutter to a minimum | Some issues with verbal clutter, lack of eye contact, lack of expression, halting, incorrect use of vocabulary or grammar | Major issues with verbal clutter, lack of eye contact, lack of expression, halting, incorrect use of vocabulary or grammar that inhibit understanding |